

GENDER, MARKETS, AND ECONOMIC AGENCIES IN WEST AFRICA

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Abstract

This study presents a comparative bibliographical review of African market women and their economic agency through an intra- and inter-state comparison, with particular focus on Ghana and Nigeria between 1960 and 2010. Drawing from historical, sociological, and economic literature, the review examines the evolution of markets as indigenous economic institutions that predated colonialism and continued into the post-colonial era. It highlights the central role of women in African markets, noting that a significant proportion of traders---particularly in West Africa---are women who engage in agricultural trade, food distribution, small-scale manufacturing, and informal financial systems. The study explores the institutional structures that shape women's economic participation, including kinship networks, trade associations, religious organizations, thrift systems such as susu, and formal banking institutions. While Ghanaian market women demonstrate strong unionization, arbitration mechanisms, and collective financial strategies, Nigerian market women---especially in northern regions such as Kano---face additional cultural, religious, and structural constraints that limit their participation in leadership and access to formal credit systems. Despite contextual differences, common patterns emerge across both countries: reliance on informal credit systems, gendered divisions of labor, limited access to formal education, and marginal representation in decision-making structures. The review concludes that African market women are critical economic agents whose contributions extend beyond trade to social cohesion and community development. However, structural barriers---particularly in finance, policy inclusion, and gender-sensitive governance---continue to constrain their economic agency. Sustainable empowerment requires institutional reforms, inclusive financial systems, leadership opportunities, and culturally responsive policy interventions.

Keywords: *Feminism, African market women; economic agency; intra-state comparison; inter-state comparison; Ghana; Nigeria; informal economy; gender and trade; West Africa; comparative analysis*

Introduction

The term "market" encompasses multiple meanings across different contexts. However, in this study, it refers to human activities relating to trade, exchange, production processes, and sales of goods and other essential commodities to the public (Akpempony & Fufock, 2013). This conceptualization includes locations with access, recognized venues of trade, assembled goods and commodities, and any sites where business transactions occur.

The interpretation advanced by Falola (1960), Igbafe (1966), Ryder (1969), Roth (1903), and Ekeh (1975) presents a compelling understanding of the market not merely as a physical space but as a central institution in the political and economic life of the old Benin Kingdom. This

perspective warrants further extension. Falola's (1960) description of the market as a geographical location for assembling goods, trade articles, and skills captures the structural dimension of markets. However, in the context of the Benin Kingdom, markets functioned as more than economic spaces; they served as strategic hubs of power, diplomacy, and social organization. They connected rural producers, skilled craftsmen, palace officials, and foreign merchants in an integrated commercial network.

Igbafe's (1966) assertion that markets were a predominant feature under the Ogiso Dynasty finds support in historical evidence. The political stability of the kingdom appears closely tied to control of trade routes and commercial access. Ekeh's (1975) observation that conflicts centered on trade and market access among groups such as the Jekiris and Urhobos---subjects of the Oba---reinforces the interpretation that markets were intertwined with governance and territorial control. Access to markets signified access to wealth, influence, and royal favor. Consequently, economic disputes frequently evolved into political conflicts.

Ryder's (1969) claim that market organization in the old Benin Kingdom was distinctive is supported by the spatial planning described by Roth (1903). The development of specialized markets around Akpakpava, Agbado, Oliha, Ewareke, and the Oba's palace suggests deliberate economic zoning and centralized regulation. This level of organization indicates administrative sophistication. The well-laid avenues and road networks noted by Roth demonstrate that infrastructure development was intentional and aligned with commercial efficiency. Trade was planned and protected rather than accidental.

Significantly, the argument that the viability of Benin markets attracted Portuguese contact in the fifteenth century is historically grounded. When the Portuguese reached West Africa in the 1400s, they encountered not an economically isolated society but an already thriving commercial system. Exchanges involving pepper, ivory, spices, and enslaved persons in return for firearms, gunpowder, foreign gin, and royal regalia indicate that the Benin Kingdom actively participated in global trade networks. The visits to Ughoton (often identified with Gwatto) in the 1440s illustrate that the Portuguese were drawn by established trade strength rather than initiating it.

However, one dimension that merits expansion concerns the broader social implications of this commercial dynamism. While markets fostered prosperity and international recognition, the introduction of firearms and the intensification of the slave trade also altered political balances and warfare patterns within and beyond Benin. Thus, the market functioned both as a source of growth and as a catalyst for structural transformation. The scholarly positions reviewed here support the view that markets were foundational to the Benin Kingdom's political authority, economic organization, and international engagement. Far from being simple trading spaces, they operated as instruments of statecraft, engines of conflict and cooperation, and gateways to early globalization in West Africa.

From the foregoing, the market in Africa constitutes a unit of economic organization. Most markets attend to daily needs, people's welfare, women's economic activities, and the exchange of goods and services in society. The majority of markets in Africa pre-existed colonialism and imperialism and continued into the independence era (Chamlee-Wright, 1993).

As a vital economic unit of society, the market performs several important functions: it raises rural incomes while building more resilient livelihoods among citizens in West Africa. Additionally, it enables people to generate incomes, invest in themselves and their families, build social capital, and contribute to societal development. Markets expose the rural and commercial settings in which women conduct critical social, economic, legal, and regulatory self-empowerment activities (Walter, 1993). Markets serve as sources of processed and unprocessed agricultural goods, as well as manufactured goods in society. Most investments in pre-colonial and post-colonial Africa were financed by indigenous market arrangements, and markets provide accessible loans.

Walter (1993) stated that the importance of markets outlined above accounts for why the market is viewed as an economic unit serving as a storehouse or site for agricultural products such as cereals and onions before distribution to regions. He identified prominent markets in Africa as including Dugbe Market in Oyo State, Nigeria; Aba Market in Abia State, Nigeria; Aswani Textile Market in Lagos State, Nigeria; and the Guidian-Ruudji-Jibia-Daura border market in Katsina State (USAID, 2017); as well as Dan-Issa-Maladawa-Mutamene-Maguria, Tinkini, and Maigatar markets, among others.

Methodology

This study presents a comparative bibliographical review of African market women and their economic agency through an intra- and inter-state comparison, with particular focus on Ghana and Nigeria between 1960 and 2010. Drawing from historical, sociological, and economic literature, the review examines the evolution of markets as indigenous economic institutions that predated colonialism and continued into the post-colonial era.

Theoretical Framework (Gendered Political Economy)

This study is anchored on two complementary theoretical perspectives: the intersectional gendered value chain framework and feminist economics. The intersectional gendered value chain framework examines how gender interacts with other social markers---such as age, ethnicity, class, marital status, and geographic location---to shape individuals' roles, constraints, opportunities, and bargaining power at different stages of a value chain. Rather than treating men and women as uniform categories, the framework recognizes that layered identities and institutional structures influence access to resources, decision-making authority, and benefit distribution. It emphasizes addressing systemic inequalities through development interventions that empower marginalized groups instead of reinforcing existing imbalances (Awumbila, 2006; Food and Agriculture Organization, 2018; Hanmer & Klugman, 2016). The framework incorporates key components such as an intersectional lens, gendered power dynamics, and horizontal and vertical linkages within value chains, including relationships among actors at similar levels and across different stages of production and marketing (Mishili et al., 2009; Osipina et al., 2015). It also integrates broader dimensions of social well-being---social capital, safety, environmental context, group relations, resource control, and the burden of unpaid labor---which significantly influence women's economic participation (Little, 1973; Sudarkasa, 1981; USAID, 2017). Complementing this perspective, feminist economics challenges traditional economic theories by highlighting how gender inequality, unpaid domestic labor, and social institutions shape economic outcomes. It expands economic analysis beyond market

transactions to include care work and household production, arguing that mainstream economics frequently undervalues women's contributions (Lycette, 1985; Hanmer & Klugman, 2016). Feminist economics also interrogates gender disparities in wages, labor force participation, and access to productive resources (Fapohunda, 2013; National Bureau of Statistics, 2015), while situating women's economic roles within broader historical and institutional contexts (Robertson, 1983; Chamlee-Wright, 1993). Together, these frameworks provide a comprehensive analytical foundation for understanding how intersecting social identities, power relations, and structural economic factors shape participation, inequality, and empowerment within market systems.

Historical Foundations of Markets in West Africa

The interpretation advanced by Falola (1960), Igbofe (1966), Ryder (1969), Roth (1903), and Ekeh (1975) presents a compelling understanding of the market not merely as a physical space but as a central institution in the political and economic life of the old Benin Kingdom. This perspective warrants further extension. Falola's (1960) description of the market as a geographical location for assembling goods, trade articles, and skills captures the structural dimension of markets. However, in the context of the Benin Kingdom, markets functioned as more than economic spaces; they served as strategic hubs of power, diplomacy, and social organization. They connected rural producers, skilled craftsmen, palace officials, and foreign merchants in an integrated commercial network.

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Ghana Case Study (Institutions, Unionism, Finance, Agency)

According to Robertson (1983), the distinctive features of most markets in Africa are: (i) an overwhelming proportion of traders in most African markets are women; (ii) 80% of food processing, production, and marketing in Africa are carried out by market women; (iii) markets in Africa provide alternative substitutes or arrangements not widely considered as promising; (iv) markets and trading activities emerged partly in response to state regulations and restrictions on trade imposed on market women.

Women are active economic actors in all sectors of society, including markets. Available statistics indicate that 80% of traders in Africa are women (Robertson, 1983). Market women constitute the gender group of traders found in most African societies. They are women with

extensive experience in trade and commerce. However, the majority of these women are traders with limited educational opportunities. In essence, many are illiterate and may not understand the complicated banking procedures associated with formal financial institutions, yet they successfully meet their family needs through trading activities.

The characteristics of African market women include: (i) they are traders who understand and speak multiple languages while transacting trade from rural areas to urban centers; (ii) their credit histories are not documented in formal systems but are embedded within kinship and sartorial alliances; (iii) the majority could hardly accumulate the sums needed for initial bank deposits (Lycette, 1985); (iv) market women engage in agricultural and sectoral value chain transactions ranging from village-level trade to commercial trading firm output in West Africa; (v) they focus on economic activities related to buying and selling agricultural goods, as well as other production activities; (vi) new economic activities undertaken by market women have helped revitalize regional solidarity, thus giving rise to new commercial elites in Ghana; (vii) market women risk being excluded from formal credit because they cannot demonstrate creditworthiness in ways comparable to their male counterparts; and (viii) markets offer different business opportunities and challenges to market women and men alike.

Klein and Leffler (1981) chronicled the practices of most market women as follows: they engage or use local arbitration methods as well as the threat of ostracization as a means of minimizing opportunistic behaviors among their members (Sudarkasa, 1981). They utilize bonds of friendship to establish financial support for one another. Frequently, market women affiliate with kinspeople in urban centers to conduct their trade. At other times, they evolve culturally-based systems using the church and other humanitarian organizations. They demonstrate greater commitment to churches and organizations that provide mutual assistance or aid on a regular basis. Sudarkasa (1981) pointed out that market women extend their traditional roles in society through production, child-rearing, and enforcement of social norms. Additionally, they employ language similarities to establish connections or cultivate relationships. Market women express a strong sense of camaraderie with women trading in the same environment. Because they form themselves into close-knit groupings or clusters of three to five or twenty women, it becomes easier for them to secure loans. Sometimes, direct competitors in the same zone or cluster sell for one another in cases of ill health, sickness, or childbirth. It is recognized that market women cherish mother-daughter relationships, which play vital roles throughout women's lives.

However, significant challenges facing African market women in Ghana include: (a) resistance to external instruction on how to conduct their daily businesses; (b) those operating at higher scales who receive financing from their husbands often show limited interest in joining women's trade unions; (c) market women have sanctions for breaking rules associated with credit society operations (Kronman, 1985); (d) market women in Ghana gauge each other's behavior in day-to-day trading activities through information they generate and share (Axelrod, 1981). Commenting on market women's practices, Wipper (1981) noted that these outlined characteristics of Ghanaian market women result from strict gender-based division of labor, which perpetuates the importance of same-sex peer groups into adulthood as women maintain close relationships with one another. This pattern accounts for the bonds of friendship and financial support they extend to each other.

Beyond these functions, market women exhibit behavioral patterns worthy of examination. Principal among these are: (a) they obtain goods from each other on credit, payable after articles are sold; (b) they sell for one another as apprentices to raise initial capital or investment funds; (c) they assist members facing financial challenges to reintegrate into market culture after periods of grief, losses, death, or childbirth; (d) market women belong to and successfully operate mutual assistance societies.

It is an accepted practice in the market arena to pass audible signals alerting each other to the presence of market guards and city council officials. Sometimes they even harass intruders and encroachers who attempt to take over strategic market locations by directing insults at them. In some Ghanaian markets, women inherit stalls, shops, and strategic locations from either their mothers, aunts, or sisters. Market women's trading associations encourage members who sell goods too heavy to carry on the head to secure strategic locations nearer to market entrances. As a customary practice, market women hoist large trays of fruits, vegetables, utensils, and other wares on their heads (Chamlee-Wright, 1993). Traders in most markets are women who have established contacts with store owners in front of the market to shield themselves from regulatory bodies and their representatives.

Summis (1981) in his studies termed these behavioral patterns "market axioms." These are: (i) in the marketplace, traders and manufacturers pool resources to buy in bulk and retail later; (ii) a well-established trading position translates to substantial financial gain; (iii) each market chooses its governance by consensus; and (iv) street trading is tolerated to the extent that regulatory agencies are not present. He also identified five basic institutions that exert significant influence on Ghanaian market women. These institutions both constrain and facilitate market women's activities. They include banks, cultural associations (Summis, 1981), the church, women's associations, and reputable foreign organizations.

The activities of African market women have been constrained by banks because women are subjected to cumbersome banking procedures, formal use of either English or French languages for transactions, extended saving requirements predicated on loan access, and corporate strategies, systems, and activities that most Ghanaian market women are unable to meet. These circumstances paved the way for substitutes such as church and cultural associations. In essence, the failure of banking institutions to serve Ghanaian market women lent credence to the activities of religious groups in empowering market women. Different religious denominations in Africa have aided market women through: (a) creating opportunities and forums for acquiring credit from church programs designed for business starters; and (b) providing interest-free loans and grants.

Tannen (1990) stated that cultural and market associations are clusters designed to guarantee face-to-face interactions and bonding among market women. They help women form guild systems and establish mutual respect. These associations serve as vital economic pillars of mutual support. In addition, they provide political consciousness for their members. Over time, these associations have transformed into avenues and platforms for members to voice grievances against regulatory bodies and city councils in Ghana. During periods of low trade or

income fluctuations, they provide financial security in the form of loans to their members.

Other associations include foreign affiliates and *susu* groups (Little, 1965). *Susu* is a descriptive term used by market women for thrift and savings societies that accept either daily or weekly contributions into a common fund. Market women use the *susu* thrift system to generate startup capital for members. Additionally, it confers other financial privileges on members by enabling them to receive one month's savings as interest. Through *susu* membership, traders can transfer cash for goods. When a member experiences loss or bankruptcy for various reasons, she can rely on the *susu* fund to regain stability.

Discussing the implications of these institutions and agencies for market women in Ghana, Chamlee-Wright (1993) noted that banking institutions impose serious constraints on African market women. Not only have they perpetuated gender inequality, created livelihood barriers, restricted ownership of land and other assets, and hindered access to loan procurement, but they have also contributed to educational gaps and disproportionate shares of unpaid household responsibilities. Kronman (1985) characterized the implications of banking institutions as promoting "unionism... whereby individuals seek to reduce divergence of interest by promoting a spirit of identification or fellowship between parties... Unions do not assume opposition of interest; rather unions seek to eliminate the conditions of separateness that make opposition of interest possible in the first place." Axelrod (1981) in his analysis of banking services' implications for market women stated that "a high probability of repeated interaction generates cooperation..." Trust is earned through repeated interactions. It involves careful assessment of each other's character, not simply calculating the probability of encountering the same person again.

Taxonomy of African Market Women

Little (1973) stated that African market women are categorized according to their geographical locations, product lines, size of items, cluster arrangements, and various other factors. This classification system is indeed comprehensive. For ease and convenience, market women in Ghana may be categorized as: (a) street vendors; (b) storefront shop owners; (c) hawkers; (d) stall owners; and (e) lock-up store owners (Hanmer & Klugman, 2016).

Chamlee-Wright (1993), in her article, summarized the conditions and ingredients necessary for African women to operate successfully in markets: trust, appropriate behavioral traits and responses, personal discipline, stability acquired through inheritance, unionization, affiliations with modern churches and social organizations, experience, and other factors. Beyond these foundational elements, she emphasized that trust functions as the currency of informal markets--shaping credit arrangements, supplier relationships, and customer loyalty. Appropriate behavioral traits, such as honesty, consistency, and tact in negotiation, enable women to build enduring reputations in highly competitive and relationship-driven environments. Personal discipline, including prudent financial management and reinvestment of profits, sustains business continuity despite limited access to formal banking systems.

Chamlee-Wright further highlighted the importance of inherited stability---whether through family trade networks, established stalls, or generational knowledge---as a buffer against

market volatility. Unionization and participation in traders' associations strengthen bargaining power, provide informal insurance mechanisms, and create collective voices in dealings with local authorities. Affiliations with churches and social organizations also expand social capital, offering moral support, microcredit opportunities, and trusted business networks. Experience, accumulated over years of navigating fluctuating prices, seasonal demand, and regulatory pressures, sharpens entrepreneurial judgment and resilience. Together, these factors illustrate that the success of African market women is anchored not merely in commerce but in deeply embedded social, cultural, and relational systems that sustain informal economies across the continent.

Nigeria Case Study (Kano: Religion, Finance, Governance) Market Women in Nigeria

Bordered northward by Niger Republic, eastward by Cameroon, southward by the Bight of Biafra and the Atlantic Ocean, and westward by Togo and the Republic of Benin (Onabamiro, 1983), Nigeria emerged as a political construction of the British Government used to promote imperialism and colonialism in Africa. Nigeria encompasses over 400 ethnic groups, with Hausa/Fulani, Yoruba, and Igbo comprising the dominant populations (Ikime, 1973). The principal occupations of the people historically revolved around farming, trading, local manufacturing, and export of goods and services. The concept of market women in Nigeria varies from east to west, as well as from north to south. In this work, the concept of market women is examined in relation to trading activities in selected northern states, namely Kano, Katsina, and Maiduguri. Several markets in these states provide opportunities for women's commercial activities. Dawanau Market in Kano is the largest grain market in the Kano metropolis (Olagbegi & Afolabi, 2004).

The Significance of Dawanau Market in Kano

The Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO, 2018) recorded that Dawanau Market in Nigeria is the largest grain market, positioning Kano strategically at the heart of northern Nigeria's economic development and food security. Langyintuo et al. (2003), Mishili et al. (2009), and Gambo (2016) all documented that Dawanau Market in Kano is known for Nigerian-grown cereals such as wheat, sorghum, millet, maize, sesame seeds, hibiscus, beans, and groundnuts. Osipina and Ezedinma (2015) also noted that Dawanau Market participates in the cassava trade network, with cassava cultivated in southern Nigeria (Osipina, Ezedinma, & International Institute of Tropical Agriculture, 2015). Additionally, this market accommodates 35 commodity and non-commodity groups operating under the umbrella of Dawanau Market associations. Indeed, the market is recognized for logistics operations covering routes from Morocco to Sudan.

Basic Statistics of Market Women and Related Variables

According to Kuepic et al. (2015), statistics on market women in Kano reveal that: (a) 46% of women are aged between 20 and 40 years; (b) 76% of women have not received formal education or training; (c) 71% of these women attended Qur'anic schools; (d) 5% attended traditional schools; (e) 4% attended formal primary schools; (f) 3% attended secondary schools; and (g) 17% of the entire population pursued education beyond high school (Osipina, Ezedinma, & International Institute of Tropical Agriculture, 2015).

The National Bureau of Statistics (NBS, 2015) reported that: (i) there is 5% literacy among market women in Kano; (ii) 48% of illiterate women own plots of land compared to those with higher education qualifications; (iii) 82% of women carry out indigenous trading activities in Kano; (iv) 58% of market women have received various types of financial assistance from Western donors; (v) 71% belong to women's associations, groups, or NGO micro-credit schemes; and (vi) 90% of women are members of different savings schemes.

Characteristics of Market Women in Nigeria (Kano Market Case Study)

From the statistics above, the characteristics of market women in Nigeria include: (a) they are not merely traders but professionals with extensive experience in agriculture, trade, and sales techniques (NBS, 2015); (b) however, most are products of Islamic and traditional education with limited Western educational content; (c) the majority of market women are members of trading circles; (d) the population of women in Dawanau Market in Kano exceeds the male population in Nigeria's second-largest commercial city. In Kano, the proportion of women traders is higher than that of men. Most women in Kano prefer trading to the labor-intensive agriculture predominant in this ancient commercial city. Trading enables women to carry out a wide range of tasks related to housekeeping, cooking, cleaning, and child-rearing that can be more easily combined with trade. Above all, trading does not require educational qualifications to the same extent as other occupations (Fapohunda, 2013). The main articles of trade among market women in northern Nigeria are grains, vegetables, livestock, root and tuber crops, and jewelry or valuable metals.

The Vulnerability Analysis and Mapping (VAM, 2015) unit reported that market women in northern Nigeria are not only illiterate but also subject to Islamic and cultural practices in their environment (USAID, 2017). They have very limited voices in market administration policies and decision-making processes. Most leadership positions in the markets are occupied by men, thereby relegating women to subordinate positions. Even in the distribution of government loans, market women are often overlooked. Recently, market women were tactically excluded from government and donor-funded programs for the rehabilitation of displaced persons in the northeast zone. Certain interpretations of Islamic beliefs and traditions restrict some women and their daughters from trading in specific areas. Instead, they are directed toward Islamic schools where they receive instruction based on rote learning and memorization, and may face early marriage. On the economic front, market women in Nigeria often depend on their husbands to provide necessary capital and funds for investments. Their chances of securing bank loans are not only cumbersome but also frustrating. Market women are subjected to unrealistic agreements and harassment, first by bank officials and subsequently by landowners who may not honor lease agreements.

Comparative Analysis

Systematic Comparative Analysis of Market Women in Ghana and Nigeria

A systematic examination of the activities of market women in Ghana and Nigeria reveals commonalities, peculiarities, and differences across these two national contexts. Rather than presenting each country sequentially, this section organizes the comparison around shared analytical variables to demonstrate how similarities and differences across these variables shape distinct forms of economic agency.

Table 1: Comparative Analysis of Market Women in Ghana and Nigeria

Analytical Variable	Ghana	Nigeria (Northern Region)	Comparative Assessment
Access to Credit	Reliance on <i>susu</i> thrift systems; informal rotating savings; limited formal banking access due to procedural barriers (Chamlee-Wright, 1993)	Membership in savings schemes (90%); some donor financial assistance (58%); limited formal bank access; dependence on husbands for capital (NBS, 2015; Fapohunda, 2013)	Both contexts demonstrate heavy reliance on informal credit mechanisms, though Nigerian women show higher rates of savings scheme membership. Formal banking exclusion is common to both.
Educational Background	Limited formal education; functional literacy through market activities (Robertson, 1983)	76% no formal education; 71% Qur'anic school background; 5% literacy rate (Kuepic et al., 2015; NBS, 2015)	Northern Nigerian women face more severe educational constraints, particularly limited Western education, which affects their ability to navigate formal institutions.
Leadership Participation	Women's trade associations provide platforms for collective voice; some leadership roles within women's groups (Little, 1965)	Limited voices in market administration; leadership positions predominantly occupied by men (USAID, 2017)	Ghanaian women demonstrate stronger organizational leadership within women's associations, while northern Nigerian women face greater exclusion from market governance structures.
Unionization and Collective Action	Strong unionization; localized arbitration systems; mutual assistance societies; cooperative selling arrangements (Sudarkasa, 1981; Wipper, 1981)	Membership in women's associations, groups, and NGO micro-credit schemes (71%); trading circles (NBS, 2015)	Both contexts feature collective organization, but Ghanaian women exhibit more robust internal governance mechanisms and dispute resolution systems.

Religious and Cultural Influences	Cultural associations and church affiliations provide support networks; religious organizations offer interest-free loans (Tannen, 1990)	Islamic practices shape educational access and trading participation; certain interpretations restrict women's trading in specific areas; cultural practices influence leadership exclusion (USAID, 2017)	Religious influences differ significantly: in Ghana, religious organizations facilitate economic participation; in northern Nigeria, religious and cultural factors may constrain women's mobility and leadership opportunities.
Institutional Support Structures	Cultural associations; church groups; <i>susu</i> systems; foreign affiliates; trade unions (Summis, 1981)	Women's associations; NGO micro-credit schemes; donor programs; savings schemes (NBS, 2015)	Both contexts feature multiple institutional supports, though Ghanaian women benefit from more deeply embedded indigenous institutions with stronger historical continuity.
Intergenerational Continuity	Inheritance of stalls, shops, and strategic locations from mothers, aunts, or sisters; mother - daughter knowledge transmission (Chamlee - Wright, 1993)	Limited documentation of intergenerational transfer patterns in northern Nigeria	Ghana exhibits clearer patterns of intergenerational economic succession, contributing to stability and continuity in women's market participation.
Economic Diversification	Primarily focused on trading activities within market settings; some small - scale manufacturing (Robertson, 1983)	Combination of trading with farming or livestock rearing; diversified livelihood strategies (Fapohunda, 2013)	Nigerian women demonstrate greater economic diversification, possibly reflecting adaptive responses to structural constraints, while Ghanaian women show stronger specialization in market trading.

Synthesis of Comparative Findings

The comparative analysis reveals that while market women in both Ghana and northern Nigeria operate within informal economic structures characterized by limited formal institutional support, the specific configurations of constraint and opportunity differ substantially.

In Ghana, market women have developed robust indigenous institutions---including *susu* thrift systems, trade unions, and cultural associations---that provide alternative mechanisms for credit access, dispute resolution, and mutual support. These institutions demonstrate considerable historical continuity and have enabled Ghanaian women to maintain stronger organizational leadership and intergenerational economic succession. The church and religious organizations have also emerged as significant support structures, offering interest-free loans and business development opportunities.

In northern Nigeria, market women face more pronounced structural constraints, particularly regarding educational access and participation in market governance. The predominance of Qur'anic education with limited Western content affects women's ability to engage with formal financial institutions and bureaucratic processes. Leadership positions in major markets remain predominantly occupied by men, limiting women's voices in decision-making. However, Nigerian women have demonstrated considerable adaptability through diversified livelihood strategies---combining trading with farming or livestock rearing---and high rates of participation in savings schemes and women's associations.

Common challenges across both contexts include: limited access to formal credit, gendered divisions of labor, marginal representation in formal decision-making structures, and the need to navigate complex regulatory environments. Both Ghanaian and Nigerian market women rely heavily on social capital, kinship networks, and informal cooperation to sustain their economic activities.

The comparison suggests that economic agency among West African market women is shaped not by a single factor but by the intersection of multiple variables including educational access, institutional support, religious and cultural contexts, and historical patterns of organization. Ghanaian women's stronger institutional embeddedness appears to provide advantages in collective action and intergenerational continuity, while Nigerian women's diversification strategies demonstrate resilience in the face of more restrictive structural conditions.

Policy Implications**Empowerment Strategies: Implications of Comparative Analysis**

The comparative findings presented above suggest several pathways for enhancing the economic agency of African market women. Rather than presenting standalone recommendations, these empowerment strategies emerge directly from the analytical variables examined in the comparative framework.

Credit Access and Financial Inclusion

The comparative analysis reveals that exclusion from formal banking systems constitutes a shared constraint across both Ghanaian and Nigerian contexts. However, the existence of indigenous thrift systems such as *susu* in Ghana and widespread savings scheme membership in

Nigeria indicates that market women have developed alternative financial mechanisms. Empowerment strategies should therefore: (i) build upon existing informal financial institutions rather than replacing them, integrating *susu* and similar systems with formal financial services through appropriate intermediary structures; (ii) simplify banking procedures and reduce language barriers that exclude women with limited formal education from accessing bank services. (iii) develop gender-sensitive lending criteria that recognize alternative forms of creditworthiness demonstrated through consistent participation in informal savings schemes; and (iv) address the specific constraints faced by northern Nigerian women in accessing government and donor-funded programs, ensuring equitable distribution of financial resources.

Educational Access and Capacity Building

The significant educational disparities between Ghanaian and northern Nigerian market women---particularly the 76% without formal education and 5% literacy rate in Kano---point to the need for contextually appropriate educational interventions: such as (i) develop functional literacy programs tailored to market women's schedules and linguistic needs, incorporating numeracy skills relevant to trading activities; (ii) recognize and build upon the knowledge embedded in Qur'anic and traditional education systems rather than dismissing these foundations; (iii) provide business training that addresses product management, packaging, pricing strategies, and record-keeping in accessible formats; (iv) create peer-learning opportunities that enable experienced market women to share expertise with younger traders, strengthening intergenerational knowledge transfer as observed in the Ghanaian context.

Leadership and Governance Participation

The contrast between Ghanaian women's stronger organizational leadership and northern Nigerian women's exclusion from market governance structures suggests targeted interventions: (i) promote women's leadership in market associations and boards through affirmative measures and capacity-building programs; (ii) address cultural and religious barriers that limit women's participation in decision-making by engaging community and religious leaders in dialogue about women's economic contributions; (iii) strengthen women's trade unions and associations as platforms for collective voice and political consciousness, following Ghanaian models where appropriate; and (iv) ensure gender-sensitive policies in market administration that recognize women's numerical majority in trading populations.

Institutional Support and Policy Integration

The comparative analysis demonstrates that both formal and informal institutions significantly shape women's economic agency: (i) strengthen linkages between market women's associations and government agencies to ensure that women's voices inform policy formulation; (ii) integrate gender and age dynamics into market-based interventions and development programs; (iii) include market women in government and donor-sponsored food programs, particularly in conflict-affected regions such as northeastern Nigeria; (iv) address the insecurity of land tenure and lease agreements that render market women vulnerable to harassment and displacement; and (v) make social amenities---including sanitation facilities, childcare spaces, and secure storage---readily available in market areas.

Cultural and Religious Contexts

The differing roles of religious institutions in Ghana (as facilitators) and northern Nigeria (as potential constraints) indicate the need for culturally responsive approaches: (i) engage religious institutions as partners in women's economic empowerment, building on the Ghanaian model of church-based support programs; (ii) address interpretations of religious traditions that restrict women's trading activities through informed dialogue with religious authorities; (iii) support women in navigating cultural expectations while expanding their economic opportunities, recognizing that sustainable change must emerge from within communities; and (iv) document and address specific practices that limit women's and girls' participation in trade, ensuring that interventions are culturally informed rather than externally imposed.

Institutional Reform Priorities

Based on the comparative findings, the following institutional reforms warrant consideration: (i) reform banking institutions to reduce procedural barriers and develop products appropriate for market women's cash flow patterns; (ii) strengthen market associations' capacity to advocate for members' interests and provide informal insurance mechanisms; (iii) develop transparent dispute resolution mechanisms that women can access without reliance on male intermediaries; (iv) create platforms for cross-national learning and exchange between Ghanaian and Nigerian market women's associations; (iv) support research and documentation of market women's economic contributions to inform policy development; (v) address the politicization of government loan programs to ensure equitable access; (vi) reduce women's economic dependency by expanding access to productive resources and capital.

These empowerment strategies, grounded in the comparative analysis of Ghanaian and Nigerian market women, recognize that sustainable change requires building upon existing institutions and practices while addressing specific structural constraints identified through systematic comparison.

Conclusion

This comparative bibliographical review has examined the economic agency of market women in Ghana and Nigeria between 1960 and 2010, analyzing the institutional structures, cultural contexts, and historical patterns that shape women's participation in West African informal economies. The study demonstrates that African market women are not merely traders but economic agents whose activities predate colonial rule and continue to constitute vital components of national and regional economies.

The comparative analysis reveals that while Ghanaian and Nigerian market women share common challenges---including limited access to formal credit, educational constraints, and marginalization from governance structures---the specific configurations of these challenges differ substantially across contexts. Ghanaian women have developed robust indigenous institutions, including *susu* thrift systems and trade unions, that provide alternative mechanisms for credit access, dispute resolution, and mutual support. These institutions demonstrate considerable historical continuity and have enabled stronger organizational leadership and intergenerational economic succession. In northern Nigeria, market women face more pronounced structural constraints, particularly regarding educational access and participation in market governance, yet have demonstrated resilience through diversified livelihood

strategies and high rates of participation in savings schemes.

The study contributes to scholarship on gender, markets, and informal economies in West Africa by systematically comparing two national contexts across shared analytical variables. This comparative approach reveals that economic agency is shaped not by any single factor but by the intersection of educational access, institutional support, religious and cultural contexts, and historical patterns of organization. The findings underscore the importance of contextually grounded analysis that recognizes both common patterns and specific variations in women's economic experiences.

Several limitations of this bibliographical review should be acknowledged. The study relies on existing published literature and statistical data, which may not capture the full range of women's experiences, particularly in northern Nigeria where documentation is limited. The temporal focus on 1960-2010 necessarily excludes more recent developments in market women's organizing and policy responses. Future research should examine contemporary patterns, including the impacts of digital financial services, changing religious dynamics, and evolving policy frameworks on market women's economic agency.

The policy implications emerging from this analysis emphasize the need for institutional reforms that build upon existing indigenous structures while addressing specific constraints identified through systematic comparison. Sustainable empowerment requires gender-sensitive governance, inclusive financial systems, culturally responsive educational interventions, and recognition of market women as critical economic agents whose contributions extend beyond trade to social cohesion and community development. African market women, as this review demonstrates, are economic stimulators and professionals in the field of commerce whose continued empowerment is essential for equitable and sustainable development in West Africa.

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